discussions: as he said, the Americans hold 99 per cent of the cards in the Middle East. Sadat realised that the US government wanted peace and friendship with the Arab states in the Middle East. As an Arab, he hoped he could persuade the US government to use its influence with the Israelis. He sacked the members of his government who were anti-American. The USA, however, was too busy with the war in Vietnam. Besides, the six million Jews in America would oppose any attempt by the US government to 'bully' the Israelis. So the year 1971 ended, as it had begun, with 'no peace, no war'.

Sadat continued to secure aircraft and arms from the Soviet Union but they would not provide Egypt with the type of equipment it needed to make a successful attack across the Canal possible. More significantly, the Soviets could not exert any leverage over the Israelis. In 1972, Sadat expelled all 15,000 Soviet advisers who had been training Egypt's armed forces. This was a popular move as Soviet interference in Egyptian affairs had been resented, especially by the army. This still made little difference to the United States' attitude.

In 1972, Sadat decided that the stalemate could only be broken by war. He knew that weaponry, training and planning in the army had been much improved, especially with Soviet aid, but he would need further support from abroad in order to force the Israelis out of Sinai. He now had strong financial support from the oil-rich state of Saudi Arabia. Also, the new Syrian leader, President Assad, became a close ally. Both Sadat and Assad realised that they would have to act soon if they were to recover Sinai and the Golan Heights, the lands they had lost in 1967. The Israelis were increasing their control of these areas: they were building new Jewish settlements and kept many troops there. Secretly, the Egyptian and Syrian leaders prepared for war. In September, Sadat made a defiant speech in Cairo:

> The United States is still under Zionist pressure and is wearing Zionist spectacles. The United States will have to take off those spectacles before they talk to us. We have had enough talk. We know our goal and we are determined to attain it.

Key term

Yom Kippur
Day of Atonement, an important Jewish religious day of fasting and an annual Jewish holiday.

Very few people took his speech seriously. They had heard it all before. So had the Israelis, who had a low opinion of the Arab armies anyway. They were in for a shock.

Key question
What happened in the early stages of the war?

The fighting, October 1973

On 6 October Egypt and Syria attacked. It was **Yom Kippur**, a holiday and the holiest day of the Jewish year. This meant that many soldiers were on leave. The Israelis were caught completely by surprise. Over 90,000 Egyptian soldiers and 850 tanks crossed the Suez Canal in the first 24 hours, destroying 300 Israeli tanks and regaining part of Sinai. The whole operation had been planned and practised very thoroughly. At the same time, 500 Syrian tanks overwhelmed Israeli forces on the Golan Heights. The Israeli air force retaliated but discovered that the Arabs had